

Board Elections: A Chamber-Wide Board Voting System

A proposal to let board members open positions, nominate candidates, and run a timed, chamber-wide vote for board seats, with results held privately until the board chooses to publish them, built on the existing membership app.

Proposal v1.0 · September 2026 · Feature: 005-board-member-elections

The Opportunity

Board elections today happen outside the app entirely — nominations and voting are handled manually, with no structured record of who was nominated, when voting was open, or how the vote was tallied. That makes it harder to run a transparent, repeatable process year over year, and gives members no visibility into the fact that an election is even happening.

Members already sign in to this app to vote on Business of the Month nominees, so they're already comfortable with an in-app voting experience. Extending that same trust to board elections — with a real voting window and a deliberate, board-controlled results reveal — turns an informal, easy-to-question process into a transparent one that lives alongside everything else members already do in the app.

Why this is a good fit for this app specifically

The app already has secure member sign-in, a role system that distinguishes board members from general members, and a working nomination/voting pattern from the Business of the Month program. This feature reuses that foundation rather than introducing new infrastructure.

How It Works: The Core Loop

The process is broken into four clear steps, each controlled by the board until the moment a member casts a vote.

1. Set Up A board member opens a position (title, description, number of seats) and adds the chamber members nominated for it.	2. Voting Window The board sets an opens/closes date and time. Voting can also be closed early by the board at any point.	3. Vote Every active member sees open positions and casts one ballot per position, selecting up to the number of available seats.	4. Close & Publish Closing voting never reveals results automatically. Results stay hidden until the board explicitly clicks "Publish Results," after votes are reviewed and counted.
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Feature Set

Set up an election (board/admin)

- **Open positions** — create a position up for election with a title, description, and number of available seats
- **Nominate candidates** — add the chamber members nominated for each position, with an optional short statement/bio
- **Voting window** — set an opens/closes date and time per position

Vote (chamber members)

- **Ballot view** — every position currently open for voting, with each candidate's name, business, and statement
- **Cast a vote** — select up to the number of available seats and submit; one ballot per member per position, with no re-voting or edits after submission
- **Status visibility** — members can see when voting opens and closes and whether they've already voted, but never a live vote count

Close voting & publish results (board/admin)

- **Manual close** — close voting at any time, in addition to the scheduled end date, stopping new votes immediately
- **Manual publish** — a separate, deliberate step to reveal results, so votes can be reviewed and counted first
- **Results view** — members see winner(s) per position once published; the board additionally sees the full vote tally

Admin oversight

- A single view of all elections and their status (draft, nominations, voting open, closed, published)
- Edit or remove a position/candidate before voting opens
- Re-open voting on a position closed in error, as long as results haven't been published yet

Optional add-ons (included in the estimate below)

Email and in-app/push notifications when voting opens and when results are published. Self-nomination by members and public candidate statements submitted directly by nominees were considered and intentionally excluded from this version — only board members/admins add positions and candidates.

Phased Roadmap

The feature is broken into six phases. Each builds directly on the last, ending with a fully working election from setup through published results.

Phase	What you get
1. Database Schema	The data model for positions, candidates, and votes that everything else is built on
2. Backend API	Create/manage positions and candidates, cast a vote, close voting, and publish results — with the right role checks on each action
3. Admin/Board Management UI	The board-facing screens to open positions, add candidates, set voting windows, and manually close voting and publish results
4. Member-Facing Voting UI	The ballot screen members use to vote, plus the published results view — the feature is usable end-to-end after this phase
5. Notifications	Email and in-app/push alerts when voting opens and when results are published
6. Self-Testing & Revision	A full manual walkthrough of the entire election lifecycle, with any issues found addressed before handoff

Implementation Estimate

The table below estimates the hands-on-keyboard implementation time for each phase — writing the code and getting it working in this codebase, priced at \$75/hour. It does **not** include code review, staging/production deployment, or App Store/Play Store review cycles, which should be scoped and budgeted separately.

Phase	Implementation effort	Estimated cost
1. Database Schema	0.5 hour	\$37.50
2. Backend API	1 hour	\$75.00
3. Admin/Board Management UI	1 hour	\$75.00
4. Member-Facing Voting UI	0.5 hour	\$37.50
5. Notifications	0.5 hour	\$37.50
6. Self-Testing & Revision	0.5 hour	\$37.50
Total (all 6 phases)	~4 hours	~\$300.00

Notifications (Phase 5) are inexpensive because this codebase already has working email and push-notification infrastructure in place — this phase reuses it rather than building new plumbing.

Turning effort hours into a project timeline

Raw implementation hours are only part of the calendar timeline. Add time for board review and sign-off between phases, and any App Store/Play Store release cycles for mobile. A realistic delivery schedule with review checkpoints would run over more than a single sitting, even though hands-on-keyboard time is well under a single business day.

Next Steps

1. Confirm who is eligible to vote — every active chamber member (as scoped above), or existing board members only.
2. Approve the full six-phase scope described above.
3. Approve the phased roadmap and schedule review checkpoints and release windows around it.